language of the Buddhist extremists. They have some allies among those monks[92] who have challenged the ideology of the 969 Movement and provided protection to Muslims when they are attacked by extremists.[93] Women's groups led the opposition to the recent marriage laws[94] and are widely credited with ensuring that the NLD opposed this element of the recent set of anti-Muslim laws passed by parliament.[95] In turn, this rare act of opposition to anti-Muslim prejudice is now used by the MaBaTha and the RNDP as evidence that the NLD is pro-Muslim.

What should be done?

This raises the question of what can be done to improve the Rohingyas' situation. This book adds to the substantial evidence that Myanmar is not on a turbulent but inevitable road from authoritarian rule to liberal democracy. In reality, since 2010 the persecution of the country's small Muslim population has grown far worse and the lead up to the 2015 elections saw the quite deliberate exclusion of all Muslims from the electoral process. Equally, since 2010 we have seen substantial violence aimed at the Rohingyas,[96] their incarceration in what can only be described as outdoor prison camps,[97] and increasingly desperate waves of refugees.[98]

This leads to the first thing we can do. We can stop believing the pleasant myth that Myanmar is finding a way to democracy and that it has an opposition party committed to the good of all its citizens.[99]

This particularly affects the international community and its response. Too often the idea that Myanmar is isolated and resistant to pressure is used to justify inaction. This is not true. The regime needs international links in order to make money,[100] buy weapons, and attain a veneer of respectability.[101] It has also become very adept at playing its various international partners off against each other: for example, it effectively threatens the countries of the ASEAN (Association of Southeast Asian Nations) that if they persist in criticism then, regretfully, it will swing towards Chinese influence.[102]

At the moment, it is clear that the ASEAN has lost patience with Myanmar over the persecution of the Rohingyas.[103] ASEAN countries had to bear the brunt of the refugee crisis in 2015 and are aware that unless the situation in Rakhine improves, further destabilising refugee flows are now